The Early Period of the United States of America

The earliest Europeans to settle in what is known today as North America were people from Spain. Lucas Vazquez de Ayllon arrived in America in 1526 and began the first colony in modern day Carolina. He also brought with him African slaves for the first time. His attempt proved to be unsuccessful. Those who did not die from disease or starvation quickly deserted the settlement. 39 years later, Pedro Menendez de Aviles established a colony in modern day St. Augustine in Florida, which became the earliest European colony in North America.

Sir Humphrey Gilbert was the first British leader who attempted to create a colony. Queen Elizabeth I permitted him to begin a colony in America in 1578. Five years later, Gilbert travelled across the ocean with several ships. They landed in Newfoundland and explored the area. After a while, they returned home to tell everyone of what they had seen. However, Gilbert vanished. It was Walter Raleigh, Gilbert's half-brother, who made the next attempt at colonization. He set out with two ships to scout the coastline in 1584 and discovered a region he decided to colonize. It was named Virginia after the Virgin Queen herself. In 1585, Richard Grenville led an expedition with his fellow English crewmen. Arriving in July of that year, Grenville left some of his crew on Roanoke Island so that he could return home for more supplies. However, the colonists deserted the new site due to a shortage of supplies and returned back to their homeland in Europe.

John White was the next person to try and establish a new colony in America. Women, men and children followed him over to Virginia. As with Grenville, White returned back to England to gather more supplies. Upon return, he saw that England was at war with Spain. His journey back to America was effectively delayed until 1590. When he arrived in America again, he saw that the colonists had abandoned the site and were nowhere to be found. It is still uncertain as to what exactly happened to these settlers.